

Conquer Career Fairs

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Golden Idea

Career fairs can be helpful & high return-on-investment if you utilize them correctly. Here's everything you need to know to make the most of career fairs & use them to land interviews.

Importance

What's the main reason this idea is important to understand?

- Most people (especially students) have access to a handful of career fairs, so it's important to understand how they work and have a strategy to take advantage of them.

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What is a Career Fair?

A **career fair** in the context of tech is an event where companies, recruiters, and industry professionals gather to meet and network with job seekers, particularly students or recent graduates looking for jobs or internships in fields like software engineering.

- These events are typically organized by universities, professional organizations, or tech companies, offering opportunities for attendees to learn about job openings, submit resumes, and sometimes participate in on-the-spot interviews.
- Career fairs can be an effective way to connect directly with potential employers and gain insights into the tech industry's hiring landscape.

In simple terms, it's a place where you can meet & talk directly to recruiters from a variety of companies.

Who Runs Career Fairs & What Kinds Are There?

There are five categories of career fairs that you should be aware of — you can sort almost any career fair into one of these categories.

1. University and College Career Fairs

- Examples: University tech career fairs, college-specific expos.

2. Company-Sponsored and Industry-Specific Fairs

- Examples: Google Career Day, AI & Machine Learning Career Fair.

3. Hackathon-Based and Conference Career Fairs

- Examples: Major League Hacking events, Web Summit career fair.

4. Diversity-Focused Career Fairs

- Examples: AfroTech, Grace Hopper Celebration, ColorStack fairs, Rewriting The Code.

5. Online and Virtual Career Fairs

- Examples: [Hired.com](https://www.hired.com) virtual fairs, Tech Talent Day, Handshake virtual fairs, CodePath



Which Ones Should You Attend?

You should attend as many as you can — with the caveat that in-person & University specific career fairs are usually more effective. More specifically, the rule of thumb is that the more exclusive the event, the better it will be.

- In other words, if there are restrictions around who can show up — then there will be less competition.
- In-Person, Hackathons, Specific University, Diversity, etc.

Look at the above list and pick ~3 events to attend from all the categories. I've highlighted the three categories that are usually the most useful (fill this out in your worksheet).

Also, they usually happen in the fall (especially University ones), so keep that on your radar.



What is the Main Purpose Of Career Fairs?

Why should you attend? There are two reasons:

1. Find Hiring Companies

- Chances are, if a company is at a career fair, then they probably hire interns/new grads & do so from your school.
- This is a magical thing — it helps cut through the effort of the Google Manhunt (from Application Cartography) & gives you a curated list of companies to apply to.
- Associated worksheet — whenever you go to a career fair, *you need to look at the companies beforehand and list them all off.*
 1. Exactly how we did it in Application Cartography, you'll look at the list your school/organization provides you of companies, and write ALL of them down.
 2. Then proceed as normal — highlight if currently open, get a referral & apply, otherwise get a referral & apply when open.
 3. It's really really helpful as those companies are already interested in hiring people like you — saves you time.

2. Expedited Networking

- Career fairs help you get that referral & network MUCH easier than otherwise. Often, you show up, you immediately get software engineer & recruiter contacts just by speaking in person — and you can get a referral from them.
- Essentially, it bypasses the LinkedIn Connection process — you just meet these people in person, get their contact info, and can immediately ask for a referral.



Career Fair Schedule

Minute-by-minute, what actually happens in a routine career fair? I'll use a classic University fair as an example:

1. Arrival and Registration (First 10-15 mins)

1. **Students and recruiters check in:** Students typically register at a booth, often receiving a name tag and floor plan. Recruiters set up their booths, arranging marketing materials, business cards, and job descriptions.
2. **Orientation or Welcome Speech (optional):** Sometimes there's a brief introduction by university staff or a career services representative to explain the layout, key employers present, and available resources.

2. Booth Exploration and First Conversations (Next 15-30 mins)

1. **Initial walk-through:** Students take a few minutes to explore the fair, often marking which employers they want to visit. You should know which 3-5 companies you're hyperfocusing on BEFORE you walk in — you'll want to mark those and make a beeline for your top choice.
2. **Approaching booths:** Students begin introducing themselves to company representatives, delivering their *elevator pitch*, *handing out resumes*, and *asking questions about job or internship opportunities*.
3. **Recruiter introductions:** Recruiters typically spend 5-10 minutes per student, explaining their company's open roles and discussing key qualifications.

3. Elevator Pitches and Resume Handouts (Ongoing every 10-15 mins)

1. **Students approach employers:** Over the next 1-2 hours, students continue to circulate, approaching as many booths as possible, delivering a short, personalized pitch about their skills and career interests.



2. **Resume exchange:** Each interaction typically involves a resume handoff. The recruiter may quickly skim the resume and ask a few follow-up questions based on the student's qualifications.
3. **Employer-provided materials:** Employers may give students brochures or flyers outlining job openings, application deadlines, or company details.

4. Informal Interviews and Networking (Every 10-15 mins)

1. **Short informal interviews:** Some recruiters might conduct brief, on-the-spot interviews lasting about 5-10 minutes to assess immediate fit or interest. They often ask about the student's background, academic projects, or career goals.
2. **Networking:** Students who finish early might gather in breakout areas to network with peers, discussing company opportunities or sharing tips on which booths to prioritize.
3. **Waiting time:** Some booths may have long lines. Students use this time to review their notes, practice their pitch, or gather information from career fair staff.

5. Employer Presentations and Workshops (Simultaneously every 30-45 mins)

1. **Company presentations:** Some career fairs include scheduled employer presentations. These typically last 20-30 minutes, where companies share more in-depth information about their culture, roles, and hiring process.
2. **Workshops or resume reviews:** Some fairs also have workshops on interviewing, networking tips, or resume reviews conducted by career services staff. Students can drop by for quick critiques between visiting booths.

6. Follow-Up and Closing (Last 15-30 mins)

1. **Wrapping up:** As the fair nears its end, students make last-minute rounds to any remaining booths or return to their top-choice employers to thank recruiters for their time.
2. **Final instructions:** Before leaving, students are often reminded to follow up via email or a company's online application portal. Some recruiters might also advise students about next steps in the hiring process.

7. Post-Event (Optional)

1. **Interviews:** Some employers schedule follow-up interviews for the next day or week, often happening on campus. Less likely in software engineering.
2. **Student reflection:** After leaving, students often take a few minutes to reflect on their interactions, review notes, and follow up with personalized thank-you emails to the recruiters they spoke with.



Preparation Checklist

Before:

- ☐ Find the list of companies that are attending the event & note them all down.
- ☐ Decide which 5 are your top priority & you're going to hyperfocus on — ideally ones that are open or going to open soon AND in your zone of focus.
- ☐ If they're open & a small to mid size company, then get a referral but don't apply until the career fair.
- ☐ If they're a name brand to FAANG/Quant, then get a referral & apply before the event.
 - ☐ You always want to get on a call with someone who works there BEFORE the event.

Here are **5 essential questions** or responses you should study before attending a career fair to prepare for meaningful conversations with companies. Practice answering these for the 5 companies of your choice on the [accompanying worksheet](#).

1. Why do you want to work here?

- Research the company's mission, culture, and products to explain why their goals align with your career interests and values.
- *Your response MUST be unique to the company & unique to you.*

2. What are three core values this company prioritizes, and how do those values influence its products or philosophy?

- Understand the company's guiding principles and be ready to explain how they resonate with you personally and professionally.

3. What is the company's main product or service, and how does it differentiate from competitors?

- Know the key products or services the company offers and be prepared to discuss how they stand out in the market.

4. How does this company generate revenue?

- Learn about the company's revenue streams, including the main products or services that drive its cash flow (e.g., SaaS, consulting, hardware).

5. What are recent milestones or news about the company that demonstrate its growth or innovation?

- Stay updated on the company's latest achievements, expansions, or innovations, and be prepared to discuss how this motivates you to be a part of their future.

☐ Write your elevator pitch (unique to each of your 5 companies.)

☐ Start with a Quick Introduction (5-10 seconds)

- Begin by stating your name, your major, and your school (if applicable).
- *Example:* "Hi, I'm Aman, a computer science major at [University]."

☐ Highlight Your Skills and Experience (10-15 seconds)

- Focus on technical skills that are relevant to the job, such as programming languages, frameworks, or specific projects.
- Mention any internships, research, or projects that demonstrate your abilities.
- *Example:* "I've completed internships focused on backend development using Python and Node.js, and recently worked on a project where I optimized an algorithm for a machine learning model."

☐ Express Your Interest in the Company (5-10 seconds)

- Mention why you're interested in the company and what excites you about their work or mission.
- This shows you've done your homework and are genuinely interested.
- *Example:* "I'm particularly excited about [Company's] work in cloud computing, especially your innovative approach to scaling distributed systems."

☐ Conclude with a Goal or Question (5-10 seconds)

- Wrap up by stating your interest in an internship or role and ask a relevant question to continue the conversation.
- *Example:* "I'd love to learn more about any open opportunities for software engineering interns. Could you tell me more about what the team is currently working on?"

Key Tips:

- **Keep it under 45-60 seconds:** Be concise and focused.
- **Tailor to the company:** Mention something specific about the company or their products to stand out.
- **Be confident:** Smile and maintain eye contact to convey enthusiasm and professionalism.

☐ Act Accordingly:

- ☐ Always show up early — you'll want to beat the crowd & get to the front of the line when the recruiters and software engineers still have patience. They'll spend more time with you & are more likely to give you that referral.
- ☐ Dress semi professionally and look as good as possible.
 - ☐ Get a haircut, wear deodorant, cologne or perfume (not too strong), shave, or wear makeup.
 - ☐ Stand up straight and be as confident as possible and bring a smile.
- ☐ Your personality matters A LOT — how normal, vibrant, and charismatic you are makes a huge difference. So look them in the eye and try to be charming.
- ☐ Bring a folder with 10-20 resumes printed out as well as a small notebook to take notes.
 - ☐ Ideally, you don't use your phone and instead you write notes by hand.

During:

- ☐ Look around, note down the companies you want to go for, but start with your 5 that you prepared.
- ☐ Walk up to the recruiter & deliver your elevator pitch.
- ☐ Afterwards, focus on asking questions about the internship or full-time role & make conversation about that.



Here's a list of questions you can ask them: (all are important but highlighted are most important)

1. Can you tell me more about the projects interns or new grads typically work on at your company?

- This shows you're interested in the work environment and the kind of impact you can have.

2. What skills or experiences do you look for in candidates for software engineering internships or entry-level roles?

- This helps you understand what they value and if you align with their needs.

3. How does your team approach mentorship and professional development for interns and new hires?

- Asking about mentorship shows you're interested in growth and learning within the company.

4. What are some of the exciting challenges your engineering team is currently working on?

- This demonstrates curiosity about their work and encourages deeper engagement.

5. What is the culture like at your company, especially on the engineering teams?

- Understanding company culture helps you see if the environment is a good fit for you.

6. How do interns or new grads typically transition to full-time roles at your company?

- This shows long-term interest in the company and an eagerness for growth opportunities.

7. What's the timeline for your recruitment process, and what are the next steps?

- This question helps you understand the hiring process and follow-up expectations.



- ☐ At the end: *"It was great chatting with you and meeting you! I would love to apply to work at [company name] — I have my resume here, is there a special application link or portal that you'd recommend I apply through?"*
- ☐ Always get ALL contact info as well (SWE & recruiter)
 - *"Amazing, sounds good! Could you give me your contact info like an email? I'd love to follow up and send my resume over & ask more questions about the role, if possible, and stay in contact for future roles at [company name]."*

After:

- ☐ **Apply ASAP** with a referral through their recommended method.
 - Ideally, use the contacts you just got to get that referral submitted by the end of the day.
- ☐ Then, send a follow up email to the recruiter with your resume & letting them know you applied & thanking them for the conversation.



Conclusion

As you can see, career fairs are simply another way to get a warm application — you get in contact with a company that's hiring & are able to get a referral more easily.

That's pretty much it — they are very useful, but are just another tool in your arsenal.